

OP6 Career Path Transparency

Merged from OP5 and OP6. The original OP5 was too thin; OP6 was too verbose. This version keeps the career conversation framework from OP6 and adds practical structure.

Pillar	Opportunity	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	45-55 minutes	Group Size	5-12
Mode	Team facilitation (requires manager to be transparent about real career paths)	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	OP1 (Ambition Roadmap) so individuals have clarity on their aspirations	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Lack of transparency in career paths, career advancement unclear, employees don't know what's needed to progress, leadership accountability for development check-ins

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Career uncertainty is a chronic, low-grade stressor. Unlike acute stress (a deadline, a difficult conversation), career uncertainty operates in the background, maintaining elevated baseline cortisol that erodes engagement, creativity, and loyalty without producing a visible crisis. People don't quit because of one bad day. They quit because months of uncertainty about their future slowly drain their commitment.

Transparency about career paths reduces this chronic cortisol by providing clarity, even when the clarity is 'this path is difficult' or 'that role doesn't exist here.' The brain can plan around known constraints. It cannot plan around unknown ones. Honest transparency, even when the message is hard, is less stressful than ambiguity.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Path Map (15 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"I want to be transparent about what career progression actually looks like in this organisation. Not the aspirational version. The real one. I'm going to share what I know about the paths available, what's required for each, and where the gaps or limitations are. Then I want your honest questions."

The manager maps available career paths on the flipchart/Miro. For each path, be explicit about:

- What the role requires (skills, experience, qualifications)
- What the timeline typically looks like (not promises, but realistic patterns)
- What the manager can and cannot influence ("I can advocate but the decision sits with...")
- Where paths are genuinely blocked and why ("This role hasn't opened in two years because...")

Phase 2: The Honest Q&A (15 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"What questions do you have that you've never felt comfortable asking about your career here? This is the session to ask them. I'll answer honestly, including when the answer is 'I don't know' or 'that path doesn't exist right now.'"

Allow anonymous question submission (written cards or Mentimeter) alongside verbal questions. The anonymous channel surfaces questions people are afraid to ask publicly: "Is there really a path for someone who doesn't want to manage people?" or "Does tenure actually matter for promotion or is it just about visibility?"

Phase 3: The Career Conversation Commitment (10 minutes)

Establish a regular career conversation cadence:

- Quarterly: each team member has a dedicated career conversation with the manager (separate from performance reviews and project check-ins)
- The conversation structure: review the OP1 roadmap, assess progress, identify next opportunities, surface barriers
- The manager's preparation: before each career conversation, have at least one specific opportunity or connection to offer

WHAT TO SAY

"I'm committing to a quarterly career conversation with each of you. Not about performance. About direction. I'll come prepared with at least one concrete suggestion. I need you to come prepared with an honest update on where you want to be heading."

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
The path map reveals very limited progression options	Be honest rather than creative: "The upward path in our team is narrow. But career growth isn't only upward. Let's look at lateral moves, skill deepening, project variety, and cross-functional exposure as genuine growth paths." Do not invent paths that don't exist.
An anonymous question reveals deep frustration or	Address it directly: "This question suggests someone feels the career path isn't fair or transparent. I take that seriously. Let me address it as

cynicism	honestly as I can." Do not dismiss or deflect.
The career conversation commitment lapses after the first quarter	Schedule all four quarterly conversations at the start of the year. Block them in the calendar. If they're not scheduled, they will not happen.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
OP1: Ambition Roadmap	OP6 provides the organisational context that OP1's individual aspirations need to be tested against.	Run OP1 before OP6
OP2: Opportunity Mapping	OP2 maps specific opportunities; OP6 maps structural career paths. Together they give the complete picture.	Complementary
C3: Transparency Workshop	OP6 is career-specific transparency. C3 is broader communication transparency. Same principle, different domain.	Complementary

Merger and Retirement Notes

OP5: Career Path Communication

MERGER NOTE

Merged into OP6: Career Path Transparency. The original OP5 was too thin to stand alone. Its career conversation elements are incorporated into OP6's Phase 3.

OP7: Bridging Skills Gaps

MERGER NOTE

Skills gap analysis belongs in the Learning pillar. The skills gap identification elements from OP7 are addressed by L1 (Skills and Gaps Diagnostic). The opportunity-specific elements (career-relevant skills development) are incorporated into OP1's roadmap middle column.

OP8: Equal Access to Learning Resources

RETIREMENT NOTE

Retired. Duplicates L10 (Equitable Learning Opportunities) from the Learning pillar. Same topic, same audience, same exercises. Use L10 for learning equity issues.

OP10: Safe Culture for Risk-Taking

MERGER NOTE

Merged into V7: Reducing Fear of Failure (Vulnerability pillar). Psychological safety for risk-taking is fundamentally a vulnerability issue. V7 addresses the fear, the safe-to-fail boundaries, and the recognition of risk-taking behaviour.

OP12: Flexible Work Hours for Learning

RETIREMENT NOTE

Retired. Work flexibility decisions are organisational policy, not exercises a manager can facilitate with their team. If flexibility is a barrier to learning, the manager should address it through their own authority or escalate it, not run a workshop about it.

OP13: Celebrating Risk-Takers

MERGER NOTE

Merged into V7: Reducing Fear of Failure (Vulnerability pillar). The celebration/recognition of risk-

taking is Phase 4 of V7, designed by the team rather than imposed.

OP14b: Public Recognition for Informal Career Growth

MERGER NOTE

Merged into OP9: Recognition and Celebration. The informal growth recognition elements are incorporated into OP9's recognition system design.